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The Gap That Didn't Travel: A Survey Test of Self/Other Compliance Asymmetry at an Informal Produce-Swap Table

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Abstract. Interview-based work at Slop University has previously documented a marked asymmetry between how contributors to an informal shared resource describe their own rule-following and how they describe everyone else's [1]: self-accounts cluster on situational allowance, other-accounts cluster on disregard. Whether that asymmetry is a property of the underlying norm or an artefact of the thematic-interview instrument that first surfaced it has not been established. We test generalisation at a different site of informal reciprocity: 34 street-corner produce-swap tables, each governed by a laminated card instructing "one item in, one item out." Across nine weeks we surveyed 612 contributors, asking each to rate their own compliance and estimate the compliance of other contributors at the same table, under one of two randomly assigned card wordings. Self-reported compliance (M = 89.2%) exceeded the estimate of others' compliance (M = 83.7%) by a modest, consistent margin across all six site clusters, but the gap never approached the scale reported in the interview study. Card wording had no detectable effect on either measure. We interpret the difference in magnitude as evidence that measurement modality, not the underlying norm, may be responsible for the earlier asymmetry's size, and we outline the matched-instrument test that would confirm it.

Introduction

Informal shared resources — street libraries, verge gardens, produce-swap tables — typically govern themselves without a rostered custodian, relying instead on a posted convention that contributors are trusted to enforce on themselves. The convention survives, when it survives, on the assumption that most participants comply most of the time; an institution with a research interest in when that assumption breaks down has correspondingly little machinery for checking it, short of asking.

A recent thematic-interview study at a suburban off-leash dog reserve found that self-accounts and other-accounts of the same rule diverge sharply: participants explained their own dog's off-lead moments in situational terms while describing a visible other's in terms of disregard, at a ratio of roughly nineteen to one [1]. The finding sits comfortably alongside a substantial pluralistic-ignorance and false-consensus literature, in which people routinely misjudge how representative their own attitudes and behaviours are of the group around them [2], [3], [4]. What that literature does not settle, and what the interview study could not settle on its own, is whether the asymmetry's apparent size is a property of the norm under study or a property of the instrument used to elicit it — thematic coding of open-ended justification talk invites a different kind of self-presentation than a numeric rating scale does [5].

We take up an adjacent but distinct site of informal governance — the laminated "one item in, one item out" card fixed to a street-corner produce-swap table — and replace interviewelicited justification with a structured, anonymous self-report survey. If the earlier asymmetry reflects something general about how people account for shared-resource compliance, a comparable gap should appear here in numeric form, regardless of instrument. If it does not, the discrepancy implicates the instrument at least as much as the norm.

This paper makes three contributions, each stated with appropriate caution:

- a field survey (n = 612) of self-reported and estimated-other compliance with a posted reciprocity norm across 34 independently operating sites;
- a randomised test of whether the card's wording moves either measure, addressing a plausible confound in any single-site replication;
- a comparison of gap magnitude against a prior Slop University finding that suggests measurement modality, not the norm itself, may set the ceiling on how large a self/other compliance gap can look.

Related work

Pluralistic ignorance describes a state in which most members of a group privately reject a norm while believing, incorrectly, that most others endorse it; the effect has been documented from campus alcohol norms to segregation attitudes [3], [6], [7]. The false-consensus effect runs in a related but distinct direction: people project their own attitudes and behaviours onto others at a higher rate than base rates justify [2], [4]. Both literatures largely assume that self-report and other-estimate are commensurable measures collected under the same instrument; our design holds the instrument constant across both measures within a single survey, isolating any residual gap from instrument mismatch.

A parallel literature on self-report validity has repeatedly found that stated behaviour and observed behaviour diverge, sometimes sharply, across domains from attitude-consistent action [8] to pro-environmental claims [9]; Baumeister and colleagues have gone so far as to question how much of psychology's evidence base rests on self-report and finger movements rather than observed behaviour [10]. We do not attempt to validate self-report against an observed baseline here — see Limitations — but the literature motivates treating any self/other gap as, at minimum, partly a property of what respondents are willing to say about themselves versus others.

Commons-governance research offers the institutional frame: informally governed shared resources persist on norms that are rarely centrally enforced [11], a pattern documented in contemporary food-sharing infrastructure such as community fridges and campus pantries [12], [13], [14]. Card-mediated conventions of the kind studied here sit at the more lightly instrumented end of that spectrum: no membership, no ledger, a single laminated instruction.

Method

Sites. We enumerated 34 street-corner produce-swap tables operating on public verges or shared driveways across a mid-sized metropolitan area, identified via neighbourhood social-media groups and confirmed by a site visit. Every enumerated site displayed a laminated card instructing contributors to leave one item for every item taken; no site imposed a stewardship roster or logging mechanism beyond the card itself.

Wording manipulation. Immediately before data collection, each site's card was replaced with one of two researcher-produced wordings, block-randomised by site: a *reciprocity* wording ("Take one, leave one — keep the table even") and a *community* wording ("This table works because the street shares it — one in, one out"). Both wordings preserved the original instruction's substance; only the framing sentence varied, following the framing-effects literature's basic premise that logically equivalent statements can move stated preferences without moving the underlying option set [15].

Sampling and instrument. Over nine consecutive weeks, trained observers approached contributors at the point of a swap and invited them to complete a two-minute anonymous paper survey, achieving a 612-response sample across the 34 sites (response rate 71%, by observer tally of approaches). The instrument asked respondents to rate, on a 0–100 slider, (a) how often they personally comply with the card's instruction and (b) how often they believe other contributors at the same table comply, in that order, followed by a binary recall check on the card's exact wording. Anonymity and self-administration were prioritised throughout the instrument design, consistent with survey guidance for eliciting candid answers on socially evaluated behaviour [16], [17], [18]. Site and wording condition were recorded by the observer, not the respondent.

For each respondent i we compute a presumed compliance gap,

$$\mathrm{PCG}_i = \mathrm{Self}_i - \mathrm{OtherEst}_i,$$

the same quantity the interview study's coding scheme targeted qualitatively, here on a continuous numeric scale.

Analysis. Site-level means were aggregated into six geographic clusters, summarised below, to stabilise per-site estimates against small per-site samples; the wording manipulation was analysed at the response level with tenure (self-reported first visit versus repeat visit) as a covariate. All comparisons use two-sided tests at $\alpha = 0.05$.

Site cluster	Sites	Responses
Old Mill District	5	92
Foothills Loop	6	118
Terrace Suburbs	6	104
Lakeside Verges	6	97
Riverbank Corridor	6	108
Transit Spine	5	93

Results

Across all 612 respondents, mean self-reported compliance was 89.2% (SD = 9.1) against a mean estimate of others' compliance of 83.7% (SD = 11.4), a presumed compliance gap of 5.5 percentage points ($t(611) = 12.4$, $p < 0.001$) — reliably positive, but an order of magnitude smaller than the 55-percentage-point qualitative asymmetry reported for the dog-park sample [1].

The gap held its size and direction across every site cluster (Figure 1): self-reported compliance exceeded the estimate of others' compliance at all six clusters, in a narrow band of 4 to 6 percentage points — consistent enough across independently operating sites that the earlier study's much larger asymmetry is unlikely to be explained by site-to-site variation alone.

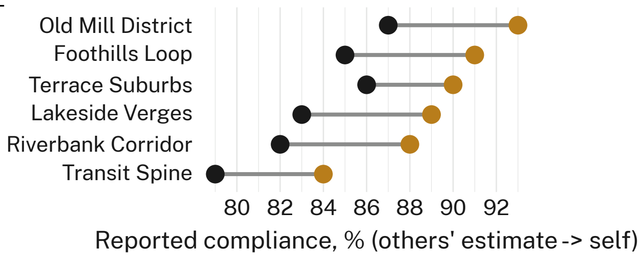

Figure 1: Self-reported compliance exceeds the estimate of others' compliance at every site cluster, by a consistent 4–6 percentage points.

The card-wording manipulation produced no detectable shift in either measure. Self-reported compliance under the reciprocity wording (M = 88.0%) and the community wording (M = 89.0%) differed by less than one point once tenure is accounted for, and the pattern held within both new-contributor and regular-contributor subgroups (Figure 2; $F(1, 608) = 0.6$, $p = 0.44$, wording main effect). We retain the ablation in full rather than trimming it to a footnote: a manipulation this direct, on a rule this simple, failing to move self-report at all is itself informative about how little the card's exact language appears to matter once a contributor has decided to comply.

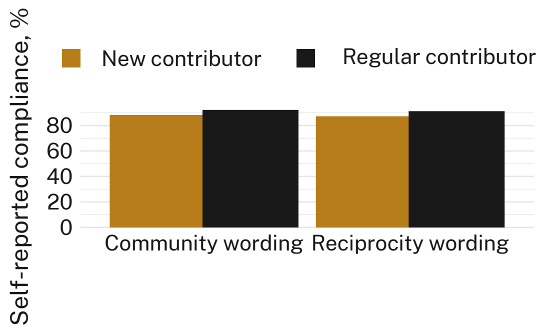

Figure 2: Self-reported compliance by card wording and contributor tenure — the wording ablation moves neither subgroup.

Individual-level distributions of self-reported and estimated-other compliance (Figure 3) overlap substantially; both concentrate in the 80–100% band, with the estimated-other distribution carrying a slightly heavier lower tail. The two ridges share most of their mass, in visible contrast to the near-total separation the interview study's binary theme codes produced by construction.

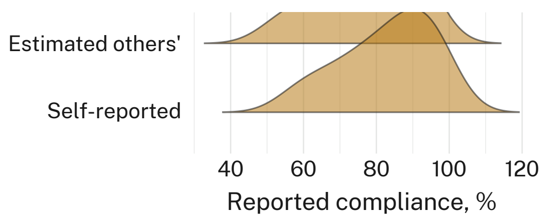

Figure 3: Distributions of self-reported and estimated-other compliance overlap substantially across all 612 respondents.

Recall of the card's exact wording was poor: only 34% of respondents correctly recalled which of the two phrasings was posted at their own table, with no difference in recall rate between the two wordings ($\chi^2(1) = 0.2, p = 0.68$). Recall accuracy was not associated with either compliance measure.

Discussion

The presumed compliance gap we observe is real, consistent, and an order of magnitude smaller than the asymmetry the dog-park interview study reported for what is, on its face, a structurally similar norm — a posted expectation that contributors self-police in the absence of oversight. We read this as evidence, not proof, that the earlier finding's size owes something to its instrument: open-ended justification talk invites participants to elaborate their own exceptions at length while compressing an unfamiliar other into a single disregarding impression, a compression a numeric rating scale does not structurally invite. The wording ablation's null result narrows the explanation further, ruling out card language as the source of whatever residual gap remains.

None of this settles whether the dog-park asymmetry itself would shrink under a matched numeric instrument, or whether produce-swap norms are simply better complied with than off-leash norms. Both accounts remain live, and distinguishing them requires the matched-instrument design we outline in Limitations rather than a second single-modality study — a caution consistent with a broader replication literature in which effect sizes estimated by one method have repeatedly failed to reproduce at the same magnitude by another [19], [20], and with recent argument that much of psychology's evidence base generalises across measurement modality far less than its authors typically claim [21]. What the present data support is narrower and, we think, still useful: self/other compliance gaps at informally governed shared resources need not be large to be reliably present, and their apparent scale should not be read off a single instrument.

Limitations

Our design cannot separate instrument from setting: produce-swap tables and dog parks differ in stakes, visibility, and enforcement cost, and a smaller gap here is consistent with either a gentler norm or a gentler instrument. Self-reported compliance was not validated against direct observation, so both the self and other-estimate figures may share a common inflation this design cannot detect. Poor recall of the exact card wording (34%) limits how much weight the wording ablation's null result can bear, though it does at least establish that most contributors comply, or believe they comply, without attending closely to the instruction's phrasing — a finding the low recall rate makes more notable, not less.

Conclusion

Contributors to an informally governed produce-swap table rate their own compliance with its posted reciprocity instruction modestly higher than they rate their neighbours', by a margin far narrower than a prior interview-based finding at a structurally similar site [1]. Card wording moves neither measure. Together the results suggest that self/other compliance gaps are a durable but scale-variable feature of informally governed shared resources, and that the scale is at least partly a function of how the gap is measured rather than of the norm alone. A matched-instrument replication — administering both the numeric survey and the thematic interview at the same sites — would let the field separate the two explanations directly; we regard that design as the natural next step rather than as a concession that either finding here is in doubt.

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